

The science of attractiveness

Week 1, Lecture 1 · Looksmaxxing

Autumn 2026 · A Ten-Week Evidence-Based Self-Improvement Course

What we'll cover

- What the halo effect is and why it matters for self-improvement
- Symmetry and averageness as documented attractiveness cues
- Cross-cultural consistency: what it rules out
- What attractiveness research can and cannot tell you
- Which traits are behavioral and which are fixed

The halo effect

One good trait changes everything else

The halo effect is a cognitive bias: people who rate highly on one dimension (physical attractiveness, confidence, perceived health) receive higher ratings on unrelated dimensions (intelligence, honesty, competence).

Key findings from the peer-reviewed literature:

- A single positive physical trait inflates judgments of personality
- The effect operates in milliseconds, before conscious deliberation
- It is consistent across cultures and age groups

This matters because it means appearance affects outcomes (hiring, salary, trust) beyond the social context where it seems to belong.

What drives first-impression ratings

Three traits that repeatedly predict attractiveness ratings in published studies:

1. **Averageness:** faces closer to the population mean are rated more attractive (Langlois & Roggman, 1990)
2. **Symmetry:** bilateral symmetry correlates positively with rated attractiveness and perceived health
3. **Sexual dimorphism:** masculine cues (jawline, brow ridge) predict male attractiveness, though the relationship is not linear

The same three factors survive cross-cultural testing, suggesting they are not arbitrary.

(Rhodes, 2006)

Averageness and symmetry

The averageness finding

Langlois and Roggman (1990) digitized photographs of male and female faces, then mathematically averaged them into composites.

Results:

- Composites were rated more attractive than almost all individual faces
- Attractiveness increased linearly as more faces were averaged
- Effect held for both male and female raters

The interpretation: attractiveness may represent proximity to a population prototype, not extreme or unusual features. Distinctiveness is not what you are optimizing for.

(Langlois & Roggman, Psychological Science, 1990, p. 115)

Symmetry: what the evidence says

Facial symmetry is a consistently positive predictor of attractiveness across meta-analyses.

Three things to know:

- Effect size is moderate, not huge: symmetry accounts for some but not most of the variance in ratings
- Symmetry improves with nutrition, sleep, and reduced developmental stress
- Asymmetries introduced by injury or illness (swelling, dark circles) respond to behavioral changes

What symmetry cannot tell you: your genetic baseline is not under behavioral control. Behavioral interventions can move you toward your personal best, not past it.

(Rhodes, 2006)

Cross-cultural consistency

The averageness, symmetry, and sexual dimorphism preferences appear across:

- Western and non-Western populations
- Isolated populations with minimal media exposure
- Infants, who show face preferences before they can have learned cultural standards

Rhodes (2006) meta-analyses: "The emergence of preferences early in development and cross-cultural agreement challenge the view that preferences reflect arbitrary cultural standards."

What this rules out: "attractiveness is purely cultural" is not a defensible position. Some preferences are widespread.

What you can and cannot change

Fixed vs behavioral traits

Not everything in the attractiveness literature is relevant to self-improvement.

Fixed (genetic baseline)	Behavioral (movable)
Bone structure	Sleep quality
Facial symmetry baseline	Skin condition
Height	Body composition
Jaw width	Posture and gait
Skull shape	Grooming and presentation

The course focuses entirely on the right column.

Perrett's key finding: diet and skin tone

Prof. David Perrett (University of St Andrews) ran experiments showing that:

- Carotenoid pigmentation from a fruit-and-vegetable-rich diet is rated more attractive than tanning
- Sleep deprivation visibly reduces rated attractiveness, health, and trustworthiness
- These effects are measurable in controlled studies with blinded raters

The practical implication: what you eat, how you sleep, and how you maintain your skin all affect how your face looks to others. These are behavioral.

(Perrett, TEDxGhent, 2012)

"Attractiveness is not just about bone structure. Carotenoid pigmentation from a diet rich in fruit and vegetables is rated as more attractive than tanning, which means what you eat visibly affects how your face looks to others."

Prof. David Perrett, University of St Andrews (2012)

In your face: TEDxGhent

Limits of attractiveness research

Three things the literature cannot tell you:

1. **Individual prediction is weak.** Studies show group-level averages. Your face is not a composite. Mean effects do not predict individual outcomes.
2. **Context matters.** Attractiveness ratings change with voice, movement, scent, and social context. A photo study captures one slice.
3. **Ratings are not destiny.** Attractiveness affects some outcomes; personality, competence, and effort affect more of them. The research does not support optimizing appearance at the expense of everything else.

Know the limits before you act on the findings.

Take-aways

1. The halo effect means appearance influences judgments beyond the purely social: this is documented, not speculative.
2. Three traits predict attractiveness ratings across cultures: averageness, symmetry, and sexual dimorphism. None of the three require you to be extreme or unusual.
3. Behavioral traits (sleep, skin, body composition, grooming) are movable. Genetic structure is not. The course focuses on the movable column.
4. Attractiveness research describes group-level averages. Individual prediction is unreliable. Act on the behavioral side; do not over-index on the fixed side.

What's next

- **Reading:** "Attractiveness research and what you can actually change" at </c/looksmaxxing-26au/readings/wk01>
- **Lecture 2 (this week):** The looksmaxxing landscape and how to read it: evidence hierarchy, bonesmashing debunked, mewing debunked
- **Section this week:** Annotate three forum posts using the evidence hierarchy
- **HW1 (out this week):** Honest baseline audit